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BL6UBL

Points to Contemplate

DATA			PROBLEM
Planet	a	T	What is the law connecting *a* and T?
A	1	3	
B	2	6	
C	4	18	

Comment on the relation between *a* and T for these imaginary planets

6.1.2 Universal Law of Gravitation

Even though Kepler's laws were able to explain the planetary motion, they failed to explain the forces responsible for it. It was Isaac Newton who analyzed Kepler's laws, Galileo's observations and deduced the law of gravitation.

Newton's law of gravitation states that a particle of mass M_1 attracts any other particle of mass M_2 in the universe with an attractive force. The strength of this force of attraction was found to be directly proportional to the product of their masses and is inversely proportional to the square of the distance between them. In mathematical form, it can be written as:

$$\vec{F} = -\frac{GM_1M_2}{r^2}\hat{r} \qquad (6.3)$$

where $\hat{r}$ is the unit vector from M_1 towards M_2 as shown in Figure 6.3, and G is the Gravitational constant that has the value of $6.626\times10^{-11} N\,m^2kg^{-2}$, and r is the distance between the two masses M_1 and M_2. In Figure 6.3, the vector $\vec{F}$ denotes the gravitational force experienced by M_2 due to M_1. Here the negative sign indicates that the gravitational force is always attractive in nature and the direction of the force is along the line joining the two masses.

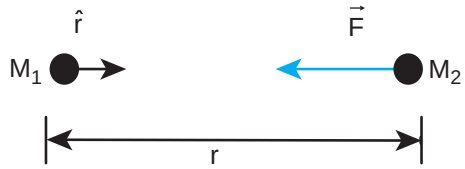


Figure 6.3 Attraction of two masses towards each other.

In cartesian coordinates, the square of the distance is expressed as $r^2 = (x^2 + y^2 + z^2)$. This is dealt in unit 2.

EXAMPLE 6.1

Consider two point masses m_1 and m_2 which are separated by a distance of 10 meter as shown in the following figure. Calculate the force of attraction between them and draw the directions of forces on each of them. Take m_1= 1 kg and m_2 = 2 kg

